

FOR OVERSEAS INVESTORS

Your UAE company in 30 days

A friendly, day-by-day guide to setting up your business, getting your residence visa and opening for business in the UAE, from anywhere in the world.

30	4	100%	1,000+
simple daily steps	free zones compared	foreign ownership	founders helped

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START HERE

WELCOME

Your UAE business starts here



Thousands of founders from around the world choose the UAE every year. This guide breaks the whole journey into 30 small, doable steps, one page per day, so you always know exactly what to do next.

1

One page a day

Each day has one goal and two short actions with numbered steps.

2

Pro tips

Insider advice from our team that saves you time, money and stress.

3

Tick as you go

Mark each day done and track progress on the 30-day tracker.

4

Tools at the back

Checklists, a timeline, a compliance calendar and a glossary.

You don't have to do this alone. Every step in this guide is something our team handles for clients every day. Stuck, or want it done for you? Message us on WhatsApp at **+971 52 346 9382**.

WHY THE UAE

Six reasons founders choose the UAE

A safe, modern and business-friendly base with low taxes and world-class connections.

0%

Personal income tax

Keep what you earn. There is no tax on salaries or personal income.

100%

Foreign ownership

Own your company outright, with no local partner needed in free zones.

9%

Corporate Tax

One of the world's most competitive rates, with 0% on the first AED 375,000 of profit.

8 hrs

To two-thirds of the world

A global hub connecting Europe, Asia and Africa.

Remote

Setup

Get your license without travelling. Visit only for your visa.

Family

Residency

Live in the UAE and sponsor your spouse and children.



YOUR ROADMAP

30 days at a glance

Four weeks, four milestones. Follow the days in order, or jump to the step you're on.

WEEK 1 Plan

- **01** Define your business idea
- **02** Choose your business activities
- **03** Mainland or free zone?
- **04** Pick your free zone
- **05** Decide owners and structure
- **06** Choose your trade name
- **07** Build your budget and visa plan

WEEK 2 License

- **08** Prepare your document pack
- **09** Submit your application
- **10** Receive your initial approval
- **11** Sign your company documents
- **12** Choose your office space
- **13** Receive your trade license
- **14** Get your establishment card
- **15** File your UBO register

WEEK 3 Visas

- **16** Understand your visa journey
- **17** Apply for your entry permit
- **18** Travel to the UAE
- **19** Complete your medical test
- **20** Emirates ID biometrics
- **21** Insurance and your residence visa
- **22** Family and settling in

WEEK 4 Operate

- **23** Choose your bank
- **24** Prepare your bank KYC pack
- **25** Open your bank account
- **26** Register for Corporate Tax
- **27** Decide on VAT
- **28** Set up your bookkeeping
- **29** Start trading the right way
- **30** Lock in your compliance calendar

Good to know: "Day" means a step, not a fixed calendar date. Government processing times vary, and some steps (like bank accounts) can take longer. Many steps also run in parallel. The timeline on page 07 shows typical durations.

DAY 3 COMPANION

Mainland vs free zone

Both let you own 100% of your company. The right choice depends on who your customers are and where you'll do business.

	Mainland	Free zone
Ownership	100% foreign ownership for most activities	100% foreign ownership
Where you can trade	Anywhere in the UAE, including government contracts	Inside the free zone and internationally; UAE mainland trade usually via a distributor or extra permit
Licensing authority	Department of Economy of the emirate	The free zone authority
Office	Physical office with registered lease usually required	Flexi-desk options available
Visas	Linked to office size	Linked to package and office type
Corporate Tax	9% above AED 375,000 profit	0% on qualifying income for Qualifying Free Zone Persons; otherwise 9%
Setup time	Typically 1–3 weeks	Often within a week
Remote setup	Possible for some steps	Fully remote license in most free zones
Best for	Retail, restaurants, local services, government work	Consulting, e-commerce, international trade, remote founders

Our view for overseas investors: if you serve international clients, sell online or offer consulting, a free zone is usually faster, simpler and more cost-effective. You can always add a mainland branch later as you grow.

DAY 4 COMPANION

Four free zones we recommend

Each one is fully open to overseas founders. Pick the one that fits your business, your budget and the address your clients expect.

SHAMS

Best value

Sharjah Media City
Sharjah

Best for: Media, creative, consulting, e-commerce and budget-conscious founders

- Very competitive pricing
- Fully online setup
- Wide range of activities
- Short drive from Dubai

Office options: Flexi-desk to private office

IFZA

Dubai address

International Free Zone Authority
Dubai

Best for: Consultancy, trading, tech and professional services wanting a Dubai address

- Dubai address and prestige
- Fast, digital setup
- Flexible visa packages
- Popular with banks and clients

Office options: Flexi-desk to private office

RAKEZ

Industry & trade

Ras Al Khaimah Economic Zone
Ras Al Khaimah

Best for: Manufacturing, industrial, trading and logistics businesses

- Warehouses, factories and land
- Free zone and non-free-zone licenses
- Lower operating costs
- Strong industrial ecosystem

Office options: Flexi-desk to warehouse and land

ANCFZ

Startup friendly

Ajman Nuventure Centre Free Zone
Ajman

Best for: Startups, freelancers, e-commerce and digital businesses

- Low-cost startup packages
- Modern, digital-first process
- Startup-friendly community
- Close to Dubai and Sharjah

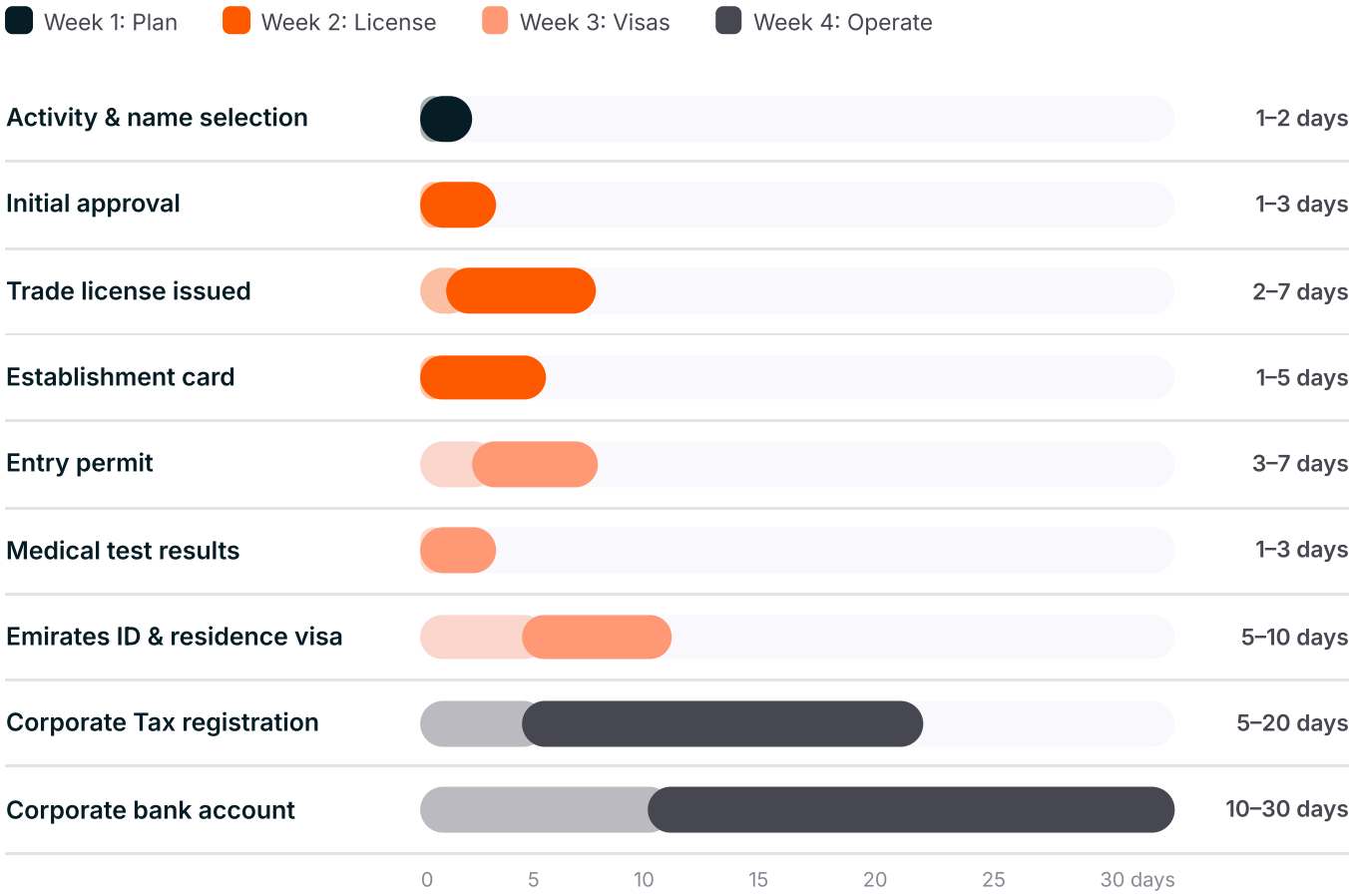
Office options: Flexi-desk and shared workspace

Pricing changes often, so ask us for a current all-in quote showing year-1 and renewal costs side by side, with our service fee included.

TIMELINE

How long does each step take?

Typical processing times in working days once your documents are complete. Many steps overlap, which is how a full setup fits into about a month.



Speed it up: clear scans, quick answers to compliance questions and booking your UAE trip as soon as your entry permit is issued are the three biggest time savers. Times are typical, not guaranteed, and vary by free zone, nationality and bank.



WEEK 1 · PLAN

Plan your UAE company

This week you'll make the big decisions: what your company will do, where it will be registered, who owns it and what it will cost. Get these right and the rest of the month goes smoothly.

Day 01	Define your business idea
Day 02	Choose your business activities
Day 03	Mainland or free zone?
Day 04	Pick your free zone
Day 05	Decide owners and structure
Day 06	Choose your trade name
Day 07	Build your budget and visa plan

By the end of this week you'll have

- ✔ Business activities chosen
- ✔ Free zone selected
- ✔ Trade name with two backups
- ✔ Clear year-1 budget and visa plan

DAY 01

Define your business idea

TODAY'S GOAL

Get clear on what you will sell, who you will sell to, and why the UAE.

ACTION 1

Write your one-page business snapshot

1. Describe what you sell in one simple sentence.
2. List your target customers: UAE, GCC or worldwide.
3. Note where you will work from: inside the UAE or abroad.
4. Write down your revenue goal for the first 12 months.

ACTION 2

Decide what you need from your company

1. Do you want to live in the UAE (residence visa)?
2. Will you sell to UAE customers locally, or online and abroad?
3. How many staff will you hire in year one?
4. Do you need a shop, office or warehouse, or just a desk?

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Your answers decide everything else: activity, free zone, visas and office type. Send your snapshot to us on WhatsApp and we'll shortlist the best options for you in one call.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] A notebook (or this guide!)
- [ ] Passport copy, keep it handy

MY NOTES

Day 1 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
02

Choose your business activities

TODAY'S GOAL

Pick licensed activities that match exactly what your company will do.

ACTION 1

Find your activities

1. List every service or product you plan to offer.
2. Match each one to an official activity on the free zone's list.
3. Check that your activities can be combined on one license.
4. Shortlist your core activities, plus any you'll add within 2 years.

ACTION 2

Check for special approvals

1. Flag regulated areas: finance, health, education, food, legal, crypto.
2. Ask whether an outside approval is needed (e.g. a ministry).
3. Note any extra time and cost those approvals add.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Banks check that your payments match your licensed activities. Choose activities that clearly describe your real business. We search thousands of activities across free zones for you in minutes.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Business snapshot from Day 1
- [ ] Website or company profile (if any)

MY NOTES

Day 2 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
03

Mainland or free zone?

TODAY'S GOAL
Choose the right type of company for how and where you'll trade.

ACTION 1
Answer three key questions

1. Will most customers be shops, people or government bodies inside the UAE? Mainland may suit you.
2. Will you serve clients worldwide, online or as a consultant? A free zone is usually simpler and cheaper.
3. Do you need many visas or a large office? Compare both options.

ACTION 2
Use the comparison table

1. Read the Mainland vs Free Zone table at the front of this guide.
2. Tick the column that matches more of your needs.
3. Write down any questions for your consultant.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

100% foreign ownership is available in free zones and for most mainland activities. For overseas founders running an international or online business, a free zone is usually the fastest, lowest-cost start.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Mainland vs Free Zone table (this guide)

MY NOTES

Day 3 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
04

Pick your free zone

TODAY'S GOAL
Choose between SHAMS, IFZA, RAKEZ and ANCFZ with confidence.

ACTION 1
Compare the four free zones

1. Read the free zone comparison at the front of this guide.
2. Decide whether a Dubai address matters to your clients.
3. Match the number of visas you need to each package.
4. Choose your office type: flexi-desk, office or warehouse.

ACTION 2
Get two all-in quotes

1. Ask for a quote for your top two free zones.
2. Compare year-1 and renewal costs, not just year 1.
3. Check what's included: license, establishment card, visa, insurance.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Always compare the renewal cost. A cheap first year with an expensive renewal is not a bargain. Our quotes show both, with our service fee already included.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Activity shortlist (Day 2)
- [ ] Your visa needs (Day 1)

MY NOTES

Day 4 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
05

Decide owners and structure

TODAY'S GOAL
Agree who owns the company, in what shares, and who manages it.

ACTION 1
Set up ownership

1. One owner or several partners? This decides your company type.
2. Agree share percentages in writing before you apply.
3. Choose the manager/director and who will sign for the bank.

ACTION 2
Individual or company as shareholder?

1. Individual shareholder: passport-based and the simplest option.
2. Corporate shareholder (your company abroad owns it): needs parent company documents.
3. Parent company documents must usually be notarised and attested for the UAE. Allow extra weeks.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

If speed matters, start with yourself as an individual shareholder. Company names like FZE, FZCO or FZ-LLC vary by free zone. We'll explain which one fits you.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Passports of all shareholders
- [ ] Corporate shareholder: incorporation certificate, MOA, board resolution (attested)

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 5 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
06

Choose your trade name

TODAY'S GOAL
Pick a name that's approved first time, with two backups ready.

ACTION 1
Brainstorm your names

1. Write three name options in order of preference.
2. Check that the .ae domain and social media handles are free.
3. Keep it easy to spell and pronounce in English.

ACTION 2
Check the naming rules

1. No offensive words or words against public morals or religion.
2. No names of governments, famous brands or organisations without permission.
3. Using a person's name usually means that person must be a shareholder.
4. Add the legal ending (e.g. FZE or FZ-LLC). We confirm the right one.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Always submit three names at once. If your first choice is taken, your application keeps moving instead of losing a day.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Three name options
- [ ] Activity list (Day 2)

MY NOTES

Day 6 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 07

Build your budget and visa plan

TODAY'S GOAL

Know your full year-1 cost and how many visas you need.

ACTION 1

Plan your visas

1. Count yourself and partners who need residence visas.
2. Add employees you plan to hire in year one.
3. Note family members you may sponsor later.
4. Choose a package with enough visa quota, plus room to grow.

ACTION 2

Build your budget

1. License and registration (your package price).
2. Establishment card and visa costs per person.
3. Health insurance for each visa holder.
4. Bank minimum balance, bookkeeping and renewal savings.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Keep a 10–15% buffer for extras like courier, translation or document attestation. We give you a fixed price upfront, so there are no surprises.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Quotes from Day 4
- [ ] Visa plan

MY NOTES

Day 7 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____



WEEK 2 · LICENSE

Get your trade license

Now it becomes official. You'll submit your documents, sign your company papers and get your trade license. You can do all of this from your home country. No trip to the UAE needed yet.

Day 08	Prepare your document pack
Day 09	Submit your application
Day 10	Receive your initial approval
Day 11	Sign your company documents
Day 12	Choose your office space
Day 13	Receive your trade license
Day 14	Get your establishment card
Day 15	File your UBO register

By the end of this week you'll have

- ✔ Trade license and company documents
- ✔ Office or flexi-desk agreement
- ✔ Establishment card (lets your company sponsor visas)
- ✔ UBO register filed

DAY
08

Prepare your document pack

TODAY'S GOAL
Have clear, correct scans of every document ready to submit.

ACTION 1
Scan your documents

1. Passport: colour scan, all corners visible, 6+ months validity.
2. Passport-size photo with a white background.
3. Proof of home address (utility bill or bank statement, last 3 months).
4. UAE visa or entry stamp page, if you have one.

ACTION 2
Check the quality

1. Save as clear PDF or JPG. Not cropped, no glare.
2. Name files clearly, e.g. Passport_JohnSmith.pdf.
3. Check your name is spelled the same on every document.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Blurry scans are the number one cause of delays. Use a phone scanner app in daylight instead of a quick photo. It takes two minutes and saves days.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Passport
- [ ] Photo
- [ ] Proof of address
- [ ] CV (for some activities)

MY NOTES

Day 8 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 09

Submit your application

TODAY'S GOAL

Send a complete application to your chosen free zone.

ACTION 1

Complete the application

1. Confirm activities, name, shareholders and package.
2. Review the application forms we prepare for you.
3. Sign the declarations and compliance (KYC) forms.

ACTION 2

Verify your identity

1. Some free zones ask for a short video call or online ID check.
2. Keep your original passport with you for the call.
3. Answer any compliance questions quickly and fully.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Be clear and honest about your business model and where your funds come from. Complete answers keep your file moving; vague ones trigger more questions.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Document pack (Day 8)
- [ ] Signed application forms

MY NOTES

Day 9 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
10

Receive your initial approval

TODAY'S GOAL
Get the free zone's initial approval and reserve your name.

ACTION 1
Check your approval

1. The free zone reviews your activities, name and shareholders.
2. You receive the initial approval and name reservation.
3. Check every detail: name spelling, activities, shareholder names.

ACTION 2
Pay your fees

1. Review the invoice for license and registration fees.
2. Pay by bank transfer or card.
3. Save the payment receipt in your company folder.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Check every letter of your company name now. Fixing a spelling mistake after the license is issued means an amendment, which costs extra time and money.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Initial approval
- [ ] Payment receipt

MY NOTES

Day 10 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 11

Sign your company documents

TODAY'S GOAL

Sign your Memorandum and Articles of Association (MOA/AOA).

ACTION 1

Review before you sign

1. Check shareholders, share split, manager and activities.
2. Check the share capital amount and whether it must be deposited.
3. Ask us anything you're unsure about before signing.

ACTION 2

Sign and save

1. Sign electronically or in person, as the free zone requires.
2. Make sure every shareholder signs.
3. Save signed copies in your company folder.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

The MOA is your company's rulebook, and banks will read it. Make sure the manager named in it is the person who will run the bank account.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] MOA / AOA
- [ ] Shareholder resolutions
- [ ] Specimen signatures (if required)

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 11 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
12

Choose your office space

TODAY'S GOAL
Pick the workspace your package and visa plan need.

ACTION 1
Know your options

1. Flexi-desk: lowest cost, ideal for founders working remotely.
2. Private office: needed for larger visa numbers in some free zones.
3. Warehouse or industrial unit: for trading and manufacturing (a RAKEZ strength).

ACTION 2
Confirm the details

1. Check the visa quota linked to your office type.
2. Sign the lease or desk agreement in the company's name.
3. Note your official address for invoices and the bank.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Start small. Most founders begin with a flexi-desk and upgrade when the team grows. There's no need to pay for empty desks in year one.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Lease or flexi-desk agreement

MY NOTES

Day 12 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
13

Receive your trade license

TODAY'S GOAL

Get your license and company documents. You're officially in business!

ACTION 1

Collect your documents

1. Trade license, certificate of incorporation, share certificate, MOA.
2. Check every detail is correct.
3. Save all PDFs in one 'Company Documents' folder.

ACTION 2

Put your license to work

1. Send copies to your accountant and to us.
2. Add the license expiry date to your calendar.
3. Add license details to your website and email signature.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Set a reminder 60 days before your license expires. Renewing on time avoids late fines and keeps your visas and bank account running smoothly.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Trade license
- [ ] Certificate of incorporation
- [ ] Share certificate
- [ ] MOA

MY NOTES

Day 13 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
14

Get your establishment card

TODAY'S GOAL
Get the immigration card that lets your company sponsor visas.

ACTION 1
Apply for the card

1. Submit the application with your license and manager's passport.
2. Pay the establishment card fee.
3. Receive the card (usually electronic).

ACTION 2
Plan your visas

1. Confirm how many visas your company can sponsor.
2. Decide who applies first (usually the investor or partner).
3. Note the card's expiry date. It renews with your license.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

No establishment card, no visas. It's quick but often forgotten. We apply for it right after your license is issued, so your visa can start straight away.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Trade license
- [ ] Manager's passport copy

MY NOTES

Day 14 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 15

File your UBO register

TODAY'S GOAL

Declare your company's real owners and organise your records.

ACTION 1

Complete your UBO filing

1. Identify the Ultimate Beneficial Owners: people who own or control 25%+.
2. Complete the UBO, shareholder and director registers.
3. Submit them to the free zone within its deadline.

ACTION 2

Organise company records

1. Create a folder for licenses, MOA, certificates and resolutions.
2. Keep the registers of shareholders and directors up to date.
3. Keep company records for at least 7 years.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

UBO filing is mandatory and missing it can mean fines. Any change in ownership must be updated within 15 days. We prepare the forms for you.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] UBO register
- [ ] Shareholder and director registers

MY NOTES

Day 15 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____



WEEK 3 · VISAS

Become a UAE resident

Time to visit the UAE. Your company sponsors your residence visa, giving you an Emirates ID and the right to live, bank and do business here. Plan to spend about a week in the country.

Day 16	Understand your visa journey
Day 17	Apply for your entry permit
Day 18	Travel to the UAE
Day 19	Complete your medical test
Day 20	Emirates ID biometrics
Day 21	Insurance and your residence visa
Day 22	Family and settling in

By the end of this week you'll have

- ✔ Entry permit and arrival in the UAE
- ✔ Medical test and Emirates ID
- ✔ Residence visa issued
- ✔ UAE Pass set up

DAY 16

Understand your visa journey

TODAY'S GOAL

Know which visa you need and the five steps to get it.

ACTION 1

Know the visa types

1. Investor / partner visa: for shareholders of the company.
2. Employment visa: for staff your company hires.
3. Residence visas are typically valid for 2 years and renewable.

ACTION 2

Learn the five steps

1. Entry permit (issued before you travel).
2. Enter the UAE, or change status if already here.
3. Medical fitness test.
4. Emirates ID biometrics.
5. Residence visa issued, linked to your Emirates ID.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

You must be in the UAE for the medical test and biometrics. Plan a trip of about a week, and we'll book your appointments so every day counts.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Passport (6+ months valid)
- [ ] Passport photo

MY NOTES

Day 16 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 17

Apply for your entry permit

TODAY'S GOAL

Get the entry permit that lets you enter the UAE to become a resident.

ACTION 1

Submit the application

1. We submit your passport, photo and establishment card.
2. Pay the entry permit fee.
3. Receive your e-entry permit, usually within a few working days.

ACTION 2

Plan your trip

1. Check the permit's validity. You must enter before it expires.
2. Book flexible flights.
3. Book a hotel close to your medical centre.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Don't book non-refundable flights until your entry permit is issued. Once it's in hand, book. We'll line up your medical appointment for your arrival.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Passport copy
- [ ] Photo
- [ ] Establishment card

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 17 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
18

Travel to the UAE

TODAY'S GOAL
Arrive in the UAE on your entry permit, or change status here.

ACTION 1
Arriving from abroad

1. Carry your printed entry permit and passport.
2. Get your entry stamp at immigration.
3. Send us a photo of your entry stamp page.

ACTION 2
Already in the UAE?

1. If you're here on a visit visa, we can change your status inside the country.
2. Don't leave the UAE while the change of status is processing.
3. Keep the change of status receipt safe.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Buy a UAE mobile SIM on arrival. You'll need a local number for UAE Pass, banking and government text updates.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Entry permit
- [ ] Passport

MY NOTES

Day 18 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
19

Complete your medical test

TODAY'S GOAL
Pass the medical fitness test required for your residence visa.

ACTION 1
Attend your appointment

1. We book your appointment at an approved medical centre.
2. Bring your passport, entry permit and a photo.
3. A quick blood test and chest X-ray. Usually under an hour.

ACTION 2
Get your results

1. Results usually arrive within 1–3 working days.
2. They are sent electronically to the visa system.
3. Keep your receipt until the visa is issued.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

On a tight schedule? Choose an express or VIP medical service. It costs a little more but can save you days in the UAE.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Passport
- [ ] Entry permit
- [ ] Photo

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 19 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
20

Emirates ID biometrics

TODAY'S GOAL
Give your fingerprints and photo for your Emirates ID.

ACTION 1
Apply and attend

1. We submit your Emirates ID application.
2. Attend your biometrics appointment, if one is required.
3. Bring your original passport.

ACTION 2
Track and collect

1. Track your application through SMS updates.
2. Your card is delivered by courier or collected.
3. Add your digital ID in the UAE Pass app.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Set up UAE Pass as soon as your Emirates ID is ready. It's your digital identity for almost every government service, and lets you sign documents online.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Original passport
- [ ] Emirates ID application receipt

MY NOTES

Day 20 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 21

Insurance and your residence visa

TODAY'S GOAL

Get health insurance and receive your UAE residence visa.

ACTION 1

Arrange health insurance

1. Buy a policy that meets your emirate's requirements.
2. Share the policy certificate with us.
3. Add the renewal date to your calendar.

ACTION 2

Receive your visa

1. Your residence visa is issued digitally. No passport sticker.
2. Download your e-visa copy.
3. Check your name, passport number, sponsor and job title.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Congratulations, you're a UAE resident! Remember: most residence visas can be cancelled if you stay outside the UAE for more than 6 months in a row.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Insurance certificate
- [ ] E-visa
- [ ] Emirates ID

MY NOTES

Day 21 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
22

Family and settling in

TODAY'S GOAL
Plan family sponsorship and sort out everyday life admin.

ACTION 1
Plan family sponsorship

1. Check the minimum income needed to sponsor your family.
2. Collect your marriage certificate and children's birth certificates.
3. Attest these in your home country and in the UAE.

ACTION 2
Settle in

1. Rent a home with a registered tenancy contract (Ejari in Dubai).
2. Open a personal bank account.
3. Check if you can convert your driving licence directly.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Start attesting family documents early. It's often the slowest step, taking 2–4 weeks from abroad. We can guide you through each stage.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Marriage certificate (attested)
- [ ] Birth certificates (attested)
- [ ] Tenancy contract

MY NOTES

Day 22 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____



WEEK 4 · OPERATE

Open for business

The final week turns your company into a working business: a corporate bank account, tax registrations, clean bookkeeping and a compliance calendar, so nothing catches you out.

Day 23	Choose your bank
Day 24	Prepare your bank KYC pack
Day 25	Open your bank account
Day 26	Register for Corporate Tax
Day 27	Decide on VAT
Day 28	Set up your bookkeeping
Day 29	Start trading the right way
Day 30	Lock in your compliance calendar

By the end of this week you'll have

- ✔ Corporate bank account application
- ✔ Corporate Tax registration
- ✔ VAT decision made
- ✔ Bookkeeping and compliance calendar set up

DAY 23

Choose your bank

TODAY'S GOAL

Shortlist the banks that best fit your business profile.

ACTION 1

Compare your options

1. Traditional banks: full service and branches, often higher minimum balances.
2. Digital banks: fast online opening and lower fees, fewer services.
3. Compare minimum balance, monthly fees, multi-currency and payment gateways.

ACTION 2

Find your best fit

1. Check which banks suit your nationality, activity and trading countries.
2. Apply to the best-matched bank first.
3. Consider a digital account for speed, plus a traditional bank for growth.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Bank choice depends on your profile: nationality, activity and where your money comes from. We introduce you to the banks most likely to say yes.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] License pack
- [ ] Passport, visa and Emirates ID

MY NOTES

Day 23 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
24

Prepare your bank KYC pack

TODAY'S GOAL
Build a complete, convincing file for the bank.

ACTION 1
Company documents

1. Trade license, incorporation certificate, MOA, share certificate.
2. Lease agreement and establishment card.
3. A 1–2 page business plan with expected turnover.

ACTION 2
Personal documents

1. Passport, visa and Emirates ID of all shareholders and signatories.
2. CV or profile showing your experience.
3. Proof of source of funds and 6 months of personal bank statements.
4. Contracts, invoices or letters of intent from clients or suppliers.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Banks approve businesses they understand. A one-page summary of who your customers are, and where money comes from and goes to, is the best thing you can add.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Bank readiness checklist (this guide)

MY NOTES

Day 24 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
25

Open your bank account

TODAY'S GOAL
Complete your bank meeting and get your account opened.

ACTION 1
Ace the meeting

1. Attend in person or by video, as the bank requires.
2. Explain your business simply, with examples of first clients.
3. Show your experience in this field.

ACTION 2
Follow up fast

1. Answer bank questions within 24 hours.
2. Sign the account opening forms.
3. Activate online banking and fund the account.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Corporate accounts can take 2–6 weeks. Start the moment you have your license and Emirates ID, and keep running the rest of your setup in parallel.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- ☐ KYC pack (Day 24)

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 25 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
26

Register for Corporate Tax

TODAY'S GOAL
Register your company for Corporate Tax and get your tax number.

ACTION 1
Know the rules

1. Every UAE company, including free zone companies, must register.
2. 9% Corporate Tax on taxable profit above AED 375,000; 0% up to that.
3. Qualifying Free Zone Persons can pay 0% on qualifying income (conditions apply).

ACTION 2
Register on EmaraTax

1. Create an EmaraTax account on the Federal Tax Authority portal.
2. Submit your license, MOA, and the manager's passport and Emirates ID.
3. Receive your Corporate Tax registration number.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Register on time. The late registration penalty is AED 10,000. Our tax team handles your registration from start to finish.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Trade license
- [ ] MOA
- [ ] Owners' passports and Emirates IDs

MY NOTES

Day 26 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 27

Decide on VAT

TODAY'S GOAL

Find out whether you must register for VAT, or should choose to.

ACTION 1
Check the thresholds

1. Mandatory: taxable sales over AED 375,000 in the last 12 months, or expected in the next 30 days.
2. Voluntary: sales or expenses over AED 187,500.
3. The standard VAT rate is 5%.

ACTION 2
If you register

1. Register on EmaraTax and receive your Tax Registration Number (TRN).
2. Show your TRN on every tax invoice.
3. File VAT returns (usually quarterly) within 28 days of each period end.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Track your sales every month from day one. Registering late after crossing the threshold leads to penalties. We'll tell you exactly when you need to register.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- ☐ Trade license
- ☐ Sales records or forecast
- ☐ Bank details

MY NOTES

☐ **Day 27 done!**

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
28

Set up your bookkeeping

TODAY'S GOAL
Keep clean, accurate books from your very first transaction.

ACTION 1
Set up your system

1. Choose cloud accounting software (e.g. Zoho Books).
2. Connect your business bank feed.
3. Set up your chart of accounts.

ACTION 2
Build good habits

1. Keep business and personal spending fully separate.
2. Save every invoice and receipt digitally.
3. Reconcile your bank account every month.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Free zone companies claiming 0% Corporate Tax need audited financial statements. Clean monthly books make your audit faster and cheaper.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Bank statements
- [ ] Sales invoices
- [ ] Purchase receipts

MY NOTES

Day 28 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY
29

Start trading the right way

TODAY'S GOAL
Get paid professionally and stay within the rules.

ACTION 1
Set up invoicing

1. Create an invoice with your company name, license number and address.
2. If VAT-registered, title it 'Tax Invoice' and show your TRN.
3. Add payment terms and your company IBAN.

ACTION 2
Go live

1. Register your .ae domain and business email.
2. Set up your Google Business Profile and LinkedIn page.
3. Use written contracts with every client.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Only trade within your licensed activities, and always use your full legal company name on invoices and contracts. It protects you and keeps your bank happy.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Trade license
- [ ] Bank IBAN letter
- [ ] Your logo

MY NOTES

Day 29 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

DAY 30

Lock in your compliance calendar

TODAY'S GOAL

Add every key date to your calendar so nothing is ever missed.

ACTION 1

Add these dates

1. Trade license renewal (every year).
2. Visa, Emirates ID and health insurance expiry dates.
3. VAT returns and your Corporate Tax return (within 9 months of year end).
4. UBO updates within 15 days of any ownership change.

ACTION 2

Celebrate and plan ahead

1. Tick off your 30-day progress tracker.
2. Set your 90-day business goals.
3. Book a quarterly review with your accountant.

★ STARTUP ZONE PRO TIP

Let us carry the calendar for you. Our compliance team sends reminders for renewals and tax deadlines, so you can focus on growing your business.

DOCUMENTS NEEDED

- [ ] Compliance calendar (this guide)

MY NOTES

Day 30 done!

Date: ___ / ___ / _____

PROGRESS TRACKER

Your 30-day tracker

Tick each box as you finish a day. Pin this page somewhere you'll see it.

DAY 01 · PLAN
Define your business idea ☐

DAY 02 · PLAN
Choose your business activities ☐

DAY 03 · PLAN
Mainland or free zone? ☐

DAY 04 · PLAN
Pick your free zone ☐

DAY 05 · PLAN
Decide owners and structure ☐

DAY 06 · PLAN
Choose your trade name ☐

DAY 07 · PLAN
Build your budget and visa plan ☐

DAY 08 · LICENSE
Prepare your document pack ☐

DAY 09 · LICENSE
Submit your application ☐

DAY 10 · LICENSE
Receive your initial approval ☐

DAY 11 · LICENSE
Sign your company documents ☐

DAY 12 · LICENSE
Choose your office space ☐

DAY 13 · LICENSE
Receive your trade license ☐

DAY 14 · LICENSE
Get your establishment card ☐

DAY 15 · LICENSE
File your UBO register ☐

DAY 16 · VISAS
Understand your visa journey ☐

DAY 17 · VISAS
Apply for your entry permit ☐

DAY 18 · VISAS
Travel to the UAE ☐

DAY 19 · VISAS
Complete your medical test ☐

DAY 20 · VISAS
Emirates ID biometrics ☐

DAY 21 · VISAS
Insurance and your residence visa ☐

DAY 22 · VISAS
Family and settling in ☐

DAY 23 · OPERATE
Choose your bank ☐

DAY 24 · OPERATE
Prepare your bank KYC pack ☐

DAY 25 · OPERATE
Open your bank account ☐

DAY 26 · OPERATE
Register for Corporate Tax ☐

DAY 27 · OPERATE
Decide on VAT ☐

DAY 28 · OPERATE
Set up your bookkeeping ☐

DAY 29 · OPERATE
Start trading the right way ☐

DAY 30 · OPERATE
Lock in your compliance calendar ☐

CHECKLIST

Master document checklist

Everything you'll provide and receive. Tick each item as it's ready.

For your license

- [ ] Passport copy of every shareholder (6+ months valid)
- [ ] Passport-size photo (white background)
- [ ] Proof of home address (last 3 months)
- [ ] UAE visa or entry stamp page (if any)
- [ ] CV / profile (for some activities)
- [ ] Three trade name options
- [ ] Signed application and KYC forms

Corporate shareholder (extra)

- [ ] Certificate of incorporation (attested)
- [ ] Memorandum & Articles of the parent company (attested)
- [ ] Board resolution to set up the UAE company (attested)
- [ ] Register of shareholders and directors
- [ ] Passport of the authorised signatory

For your visa

- [ ] Original passport
- [ ] Digital passport photo
- [ ] Entry permit / change of status
- [ ] Medical fitness test
- [ ] Emirates ID biometrics
- [ ] Health insurance certificate

Company documents you receive

- [ ] Trade license
- [ ] Certificate of incorporation
- [ ] Memorandum / Articles of Association
- [ ] Share certificate
- [ ] Lease / flexi-desk agreement
- [ ] Establishment card
- [ ] UBO register

DAY 24 COMPANION

Bank account readiness checklist

Banks open accounts for businesses they understand. A complete pack is your fastest route to a yes.

Company

- [ ] Trade license and certificate of incorporation
- [ ] MOA / AOA and share certificate
- [ ] Lease or flexi-desk agreement
- [ ] Establishment card
- [ ] Board resolution naming the account signatory

Shareholders & signatories

- [ ] Passport, residence visa and Emirates ID
- [ ] CV / LinkedIn profile showing relevant experience
- [ ] Proof of residential address
- [ ] Personal bank statements (6 months)

Your business story

- [ ] 1–2 page business plan
- [ ] Expected monthly turnover and transaction volume
- [ ] Main countries you'll send money to and receive it from
- [ ] Key clients and suppliers (names, countries)
- [ ] Contracts, invoices or letters of intent
- [ ] Proof of source of funds / initial capital
- [ ] Company website and email on your own domain

DAY 30 COMPANION

Your compliance calendar

The dates every UAE company owner must know. Write your own due dates in the last column.

What	How often	Key point	My date
Trade license renewal	Every 12 months	Start 30–60 days before expiry	
Establishment card	Renews with your license	Needed to keep sponsoring visas	
Residence visa & Emirates ID	Typically every 2 years	Avoid more than 6 months in a row outside the UAE	
Health insurance	Every 12 months	Must stay active for every visa holder	
Office / flexi-desk lease	Every 12 months	Usually renewed with the license	
VAT return	Usually quarterly	Due within 28 days after each tax period	
Corporate Tax return	Once a year	Due within 9 months of financial year end	
Audited financial statements	Once a year	Required for Qualifying Free Zone Persons; many free zones require them too	
UBO register update	When ownership changes	Update within 15 days of any change	
Bookkeeping & bank reconciliation	Every month	Keep records for at least 7 years	

Never miss a deadline: Startup Zone's accounting and compliance clients get reminders for every renewal and tax filing, plus bookkeeping, VAT and Corporate Tax returns handled for them.

GLOSSARY

UAE business terms, made simple

The words you'll hear most during your setup, in plain English.

AOA / MOA
Articles / Memorandum of Association: your company's founding rulebook.

Corporate Tax (CT)
UAE tax on business profits: 9% above AED 375,000.

Emirates ID
Your UAE identity card, issued to every resident.

EmaraTax
The Federal Tax Authority's online portal for VAT and Corporate Tax.

Ejari
Dubai's official system for registering tenancy contracts.

Entry permit
Permission to enter the UAE to complete your residence visa.

Establishment card
Immigration file that lets your company sponsor visas.

FTA
Federal Tax Authority, which runs VAT and Corporate Tax.

FZE / FZCO / FZ-LLC
Free zone company types. Names vary by free zone.

Flexi-desk
Shared desk space that meets free zone office requirements.

Initial approval
First green light from the authority for your name and activities.

KYC
'Know Your Customer': identity and background checks.

Mainland
Companies licensed by an emirate's Department of Economy.

QFZP
Qualifying Free Zone Person: can pay 0% CT on qualifying income.

Share capital
The value of shares stated in your MOA.

TRN
Tax Registration Number, shown on tax invoices.

UAE Pass
The national digital ID app for government services.

UBO
Ultimate Beneficial Owner: a person owning or controlling 25%+.

VAT
Value Added Tax, charged at 5% in the UAE.

FAQ

Questions overseas investors ask us

Q. Do I need to be in the UAE to set up my company?

No. Your license can be issued fully remotely. You only need to visit for your visa medical test and Emirates ID, and often for your bank meeting.

Q. Can I own 100% of my company?

Yes. Free zone companies are 100% foreign-owned, and so are most mainland activities.

Q. How long does it take?

A free zone license is often ready within a week. With your visa, plan for about 3–4 weeks. Bank accounts vary and can take 2–6 weeks.

Q. Do I have to deposit share capital?

In most free zones you don't need to deposit it upfront, but rules vary. We'll confirm for your free zone.

Q. Can I keep living abroad?

Yes, but to keep your residence visa you should generally not stay outside the UAE for more than 6 months in a row.

Q. Will I pay tax?

There's no personal income tax. Your company may pay 9% Corporate Tax on profit above AED 375,000, or 0% on qualifying free zone income. VAT is 5% once registered.

Important: This guide is general information correct as of November 2026. It is not legal or tax advice. UAE rules, fees, processing times and requirements change regularly and vary by free zone, nationality and bank. Speak to the Startup Zone team for advice on your situation. Photos: Unsplash.



Ready to start? We'll do it with you.

From your first question to your first invoice, Startup Zone handles your company setup, visas, bank introductions, VAT, Corporate Tax and bookkeeping, at a fixed price with no surprises.

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